Me Too – A Program

By Andrea Gibson and Pages Matam

Rape is a coward hiding its face in the make-up of silence, a murderous fruit that grows best in the shadows of taboo.

–Pages Matam

INTRODUCTION

According to RAINN, the Rape, Abuse & Incest National Network, every 68 seconds someone in the U.S. is sexually assaulted; and every 9 minutes, that victim is a child. But what is more tragic is that only 25 of every 1,000 predators will end up in prison. (https://www.rainn.org/statistics)

Sexual violence permeates our culture, from violent rape scenes in movies and on TV, to near-daily stories of sexual assaults on college campuses that go unreported to law enforcement. Remember Larry Nassar? A former Olympic physician convicted of sexually abusing more than 500 women. Or how about former President Donald Trump who has been publicly accused of sexually assaulting more than 15 women and was recorded boasting about his abusive conduct?

As controversial, embarrassing or taboo as it is to speak about, the #MeToo Movement has struggled to give voice to those devastated by rape and sexual assault. Today I raise my voice . . . .

Me Too – A program comprised of 2 poems: Blue Blanket by Andrea Gibson and Pinatas by Pages Matam.

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Blue Blanket by Andrea Gibson

(Pg 36-39) Still there are days when there is no way,

not even a chance,

that I'd dare for even a second

glance at the reflection of my body in the mirror

and she knows why.

Like I know why she only cries

when she feels like she's about to lose control.

She knows how much control is worth,

knows how much a woman can lose when her power to move

is taken away

by a grip so thick with hate

it could clip the wings of Isis,

leave the next eight generations of your blood shaking.

And tonight

something inside me is breaking,

my heart beating so deep beneath the sheets of her pain
I could give every tear she's crying a year, a name,
and a face I'd forever erase from her mind if I could.

But how much closer to free would any of us be
if even a few of us forgot
what too many women in this world cannot.
And I'm thinking, "What the hell would you tell your
daughter?
Your someday daughter
when you have to hold her beautiful face
to the beat up face of this place
that hasn't learned the meaning of
STOP.

What would you tell your daughter of the womb raped
empty,
the eyes swollen shut,
the gut too frightened to hold food,
the thousands upon thousands of bodies used?

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It was seven minutes of the worst kind of hell.
Seven.
And she stopped believing in heaven.

distrust became her law,
fear her bible,
the only chance of survival . . .
don't trust any of them.

Bolt the doors to your home,
iron gate your windows,
walking to your car alone
get the key in the lock like
please please please please open
like already you can feel
that five-fingered noose around your neck
two hundred pounds of hatred
digging graves into the sacred soil of your flesh
please please please please open
already you're choking for your breath
listening for the broken record of the defense,
Answer the question,

Answer the question.

Answer the question, miss!

Why am I on trial for this?
Would you talk to your daughter,
your sister, your mother like this?
I am generations of daughters, sisters, mothers,
our bodies battlefields, war grounds
beneath the weapons of your brothers' hands.

Do you know they've found landmines
in broken women's souls?
Black holes in the parts of their hearts
that once sang symphonies of creation
bright as the light on infinity's halo?

She says, "I remember the way love
used to glow on my skin
before he made his way in
now every touch feels like a sin
that could crucify Medusa, Kali, Oshun, Mary
bury me in a blue blanket so their god doesn't know I'm a girl,

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cut off my curls,
I want peace when I'm dead."
Her friend knocks at the door,
"It's been three weeks,
don't you think it's time you got out of bed?"
"No, the ceiling fan still feels like his breath,
I think I need just a few more days of rest, please."

Bruises on her knees from praying to forget.
She's heard stories of Vietnam vets
who can still feel the tingling of their amputated limbs.
She's wondering how many women are walking around this world
feeling the tingling of their amputated wings,
remembering what it was to fly, to sing.

Tonight she's not wondering
what she would tell her daughter.
She knows what she would tell her daughter.
She'd ask her, "What gods do you believe in?
I'll build you temple of mirrors so you can see them.
Pick the brightest star you ever wished on.

I'll show you the light in you
that made that wish come true. . . "

Tonight she's not asking you what you would tell your
daughter.
She's life deep in the hell, the slaughter,
has already died a thousand deaths with every unsteady
breath,
a thousand graves in every pore of her flesh
and she knows the war's not over,
knows there's bleeding to come,
knows she's far from the only woman or girl
trusting this world no more than the hands
trust rusted barbed wire.

She was whole before that night.
Believed in heaven before that night,
and she's not only one.
She knows she won't be the only one.
She's not asking what you're gonna tell your daughter.
She's asking what you're going to teach
your son.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Andrea Gibson
Book: Pole Dancing to Gospel Hymns, Pg 36-39
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Publisher: Write Bloody Publishing
Date (Month/Year): June 2008

AWARD HISTORY

2010 National Qualifier (this poem only)
2019 National Qualifier
2019 National Qualifier – MS (this poem only)
2020 National Qualifier – MS (this poem only)
KS State Qualifier (this poem only)

Pinatas by Pages Matam

(Pg 37-38) To the man on the bus
I overheard tell a woman in conversation,
presumably a friend, "You are too ugly to be raped."

Dear man on the bus,
Tell the one in five women of this country
they are beautiful, their four counterparts
spared torment ugly.

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Tell the one in three women of this world
that you will not make piñatas of their bodies.
Watch morsels of them spill greedily
to the famished smiles of your ignorance
shaped like bloodthirsty children. How your words
broke them open like a shattered papier mâché cradle,
their blood flowed like candy until hollow insides,
their jaws mangled into misfortune from
when they tried to scream for legs torn crucifix,
loud cry of eyes muted.
Tell them how beautiful their silence is.

Dear man on the bus,
from smothering cat-calls
to a quickened pace of trek home:
Raped with a dress on,
Raped without a dress on,
Raped as children who couldn't even dress themselves.
Tell them how ugly their consent was.
Tell the depression, the post-traumatic stress,
the unreported. Tell Mahmudiyah*,
a footnote in the history of crimson Iraqi sands,

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how beautiful the military's silence is,
clocked in how we don't ask and they
didn't tell in the name of country.

Tell Elizabeth Fritzl**
how pretty the flame of her skin was,
turning her father into a torturous moth of incest
'til she gave birth to seven choices she never had.

Dear man on the bus,
Tell my 11th grade student Lauren
that she wanted it, her beauty had them coming.
Tell my 7th grade student Mickayla
that she wanted it, her beauty had him coming.
Tell my 3rd grade student Andre
that he wanted it, his beauty had him coming.
Tell the 8-year-old me
the God in me I loved fiercely was so gorgeous
that cousin twice my age
wanted to molest the Holy out of me,
peeled raw, until I was as ugly as she was.

Rape is a coward hiding its face

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in the makeup of silence,
a murderous fruit that grows best
in the shadows of taboo,

a Vietnam prostitute with red, white and blue skin.
A murmur of bodies left vacant by the souls that spend
years, pills, poems, and even death
trying to learn how to reclaim them.

Dear nameless assailant,
How this bus carries the burden
of your stick and blindfold patriarchy
that has only taught you to treat women
like ceiling-strung jugs. Violence claws up
from your throat like a monstrous accomplice
to the 97 percent that will never see jail.

Dear man on the bus,
As these words fall out of your mouth,
"You are too ugly to be raped."
I pray no one finds your children beautiful enough
to break open, making a decorative, silent spectacle out of
them.

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SOURCE INFORMATION

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AWARD HISTORY

2019 National Qualifier
CO State Qualifier
(combined with People You May Know by Kevin Kantor)
IL State Qualifier
KS State Qualifier
(combined with People You May Know by Kevin Kantor)

* *The Mahmudiyah rape and killings involved the gang-rape and killing of a 14-year-old Iraqi girl and the murder of her family by United States Army soldiers on March 12, 2006. Other family members killed included her 34-year-old mother, 45-year-old father, and six-year-old sister.*

** *In 1984, Fritzl lured his 18-year-old daughter Elisabeth into his cellar where he drugged her and raped her repeatedly. After telling his own wife that Elisabeth had run away and joined a cult, Fritzl managed to keep his daughter prisoner in the soundproof basement for 24 years. Josef fathered seven children with his own child in the small cellar where he installed cramped living quarters including a kitchen and bathroom.*

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